Yandex Ablation: Did the Data-Center Strikes Silence Russian Information Operations?

A time-resolved attribution of the October 2026 drone strikes on Yandex data centers to Russian influence-operation output on Telegram, Reddit, the Pravda network, Russian state media websites and the websites of influence operations named by the EEAS

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Abstract

Between 7 and 11 October 2026, drones struck Yandex data centers in Sasovo, Kaluga and Vladimir. This assessment tests whether the resulting outages reduced Russian information-operation (IO) output. An expected-outage function estimated from graded published reports alone reconstructs the measured outage onsets to within 2 and 19 minutes. The output of 228 series, covering the Pravda network, 49 Telegram channels, web outlets including those of influence operations named by the EEAS, and 18 Reddit communities, is compared with out-of-sample seasonal counterfactuals using placebo windows, a Bayesian hierarchical model and 10-minute change-point timing. Only the Pravda network shows a reduction that is time-locked to an outage: its output fell to 64% of expected for 11 hours, starting 42 minutes after the Vladimir outage. No other platform group shows a credible drop, and none of 342 domains attributed to Russian influence operations by VIGINUM and the EEAS is hosted on Yandex. The strikes disrupted Yandex substantially but did not measurably silence Russian information operations.

BOTTOM LINE

The strikes caused a major Yandex Cloud outage but no broad reduction in Russian information operations.

OUTAGE	EFFECT FOUND	NO EFFECT
Yandex Cloud lost 34% of its reachable capacity after Sasovo and 78% after Vladimir, with no recovery by 13 October.	The automated Pravda network stalled for 11 hours, starting 42 minutes after the Vladimir outage.	Telegram, Reddit, state media and EEAS-named outlets continued at expected levels; none of their websites runs on Yandex.

Key Judgments

1. **The strikes caused a major, sustained loss of Yandex Cloud capacity.**

   Almost certain (95 to 99%); high confidence.

   Measured reachability of Yandex Cloud fell by 34% after the Sasovo strike (night of 7 to 8 October) and by 78% in total after the Vladimir strike (11 October), with no recovery by 13 October, 12:00 UTC. The Kaluga strike (9 October) left no measurable cloud signature. Status pages, IODA, NetBlocks, Cloudflare Radar and NASA FIRMS agree to within minutes.

2. **The outage temporarily stalled one automated influence pipeline, the Pravda network.**

   Likely (55 to 80%); moderate confidence.

   Output fell to 64% of expected for 11.2 h, starting 42 min after the measured Vladimir outage (change-point scan $p = 0.0025$), across its language editions, while the Telegram channels it republishes did not dip; 36% of the backlog was published later. Confidence is moderate because Sasovo produced no comparable dip and the network's hosting, behind Cloudflare, cannot be observed.

3. **Russian information-operation output on the observed platforms continued at expected levels.**

   Very likely (80 to 95%); moderate confidence.

   Across 81 channels, language editions, communities and websites, no platform group other than the Pravda network shows a credible drop. This includes Telegram state media, military bloggers, tabloids and foreign-audience channels, outlets on Yandex 360 mail, and the outlets of African Initiative and RRN named by the EEAS. Relative to controls, IO groups moved +9% (90% credible interval +1% to +17%) in the 24 h after Vladimir. X, VK and closed bot infrastructure could not be observed.

4. **The web infrastructure of attributed influence operations does not run on Yandex.**

   Very likely (80 to 95%); moderate confidence.

   None of 342 domains attributed to Storm-1516, African Initiative, RRN, R-FBI or the Pravda network by VIGINUM and the EEAS (96 resolving), and none of the state and IO media domains mapped here, is hosted on a Yandex network or uses Yandex name servers. Seven media outlets use Yandex 360 mail; their channels show no strike-specific change. DNS was measured after the strikes, so earlier migrations cannot be excluded.

Note. Likelihood follows the estimative scale of Intelligence Community Directive 203; confidence reflects the quality, independence and coverage of the evidence.

1. Question and Approach

Do the outages caused by the strikes coincide with a causally attributable reduction in Russian IO output, in particular on the war in Ukraine? The strikes are treated as a natural experiment with three treated events and one internal placebo (an

unexplained Yandex Cloud dip on 27 September). Each link of the causal chain, from strike to capacity loss, dependent services, automated pipelines and social-media and web output, is measured separately.

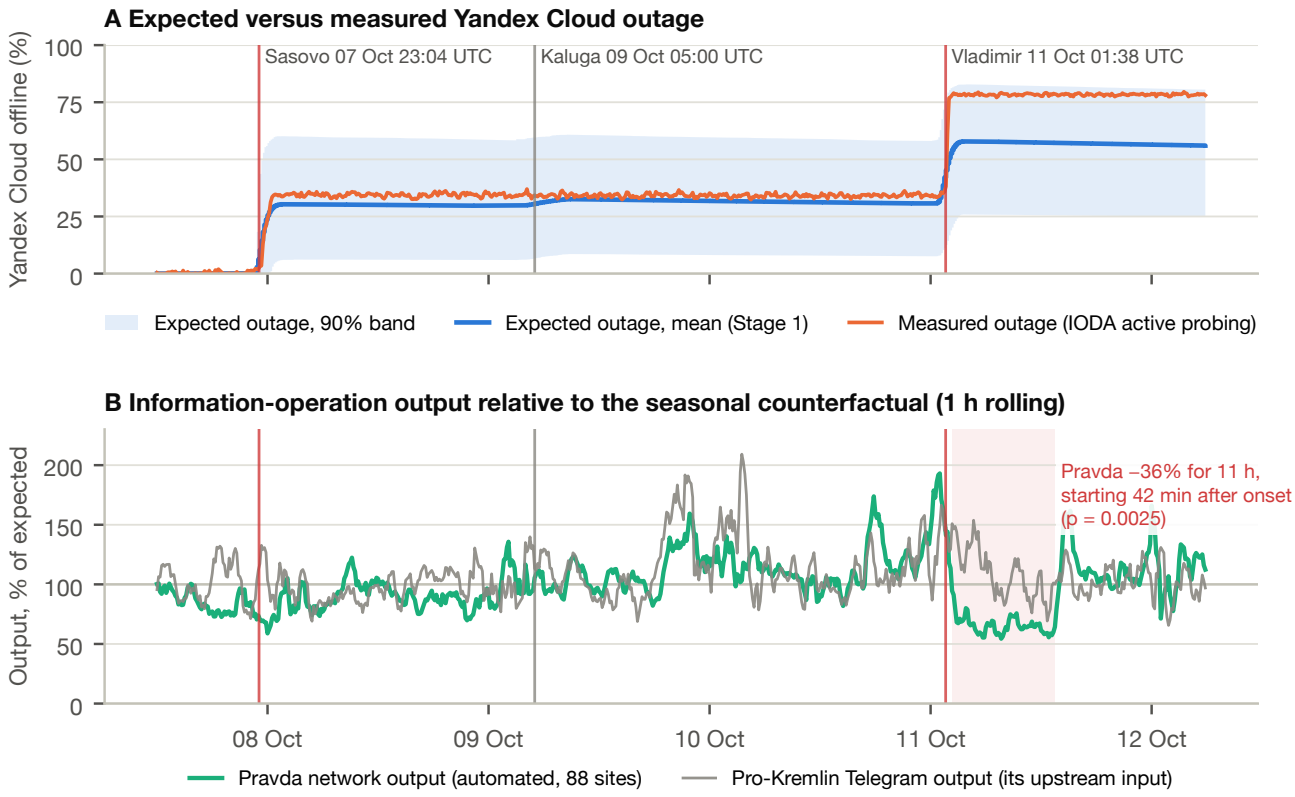
Expected outage function. Each strike contributes a capacity-weighted damage curve whose timing, onset lag, failure ramp, damage and recovery follow from graded reports. Admiralty grades are converted into probabilities and pooled into each strike's credibility. The model is estimated in three nested Bayesian stages with adaptive-tempering sequential Monte Carlo on a 10-minute grid: attack reports only (S0), all published information (S1), and fused with IODA active-probing telemetry (S2). Stage 1 is validated out of sample against the measurement (Figure 1A).

Outcomes and inference. Each series receives an out-of-sample seasonal counterfactual (hour of day, day of week and trend, fitted on the baseline only). Inference combines placebo-in-time windows of 6 and 24 hours with a same-weekday check; a Bayesian hierarchical model that pools 81 member series into platform groups, with a Yandex-dependency term and the common news-shock variance; change-point dating of dips against the outage onset, calibrated with 400 placebo origins; dose-response on the expected outage function with HAC errors; war-minus-non-war theme contrasts; Benjamini-Hochberg false-discovery control; a 20% equivalence bound; and analysis of competing hypotheses. A drop is credible only if the posterior probability of a drop larger than 10% exceeds 90%, the group placebo p is below 0.05 and the same-weekday check agrees. A dip is time-locked only if it is significant and starts at or after the onset.

Actors. The actor set follows the EEAS 4th FIMI threat report and the VIGINUM report on Storm-1516: the Pravda network (Portal Kombat), African Initiative, RRN and R-FBI outlets and channels, and 338 Storm-1516 domains, whose hosting was resolved through public DNS.

Figure 1

Expected and Measured Yandex Cloud Outage and Pravda Network Output, 7 to 12 October 2026



Note. (A) The expected outage function estimated from published sources only (statements, status pages, satellite fire detections, complaint alerts) tracks the independently measured outage, with onset errors of 2 min (Sasovo) and 19 min (Vladimir) and 99% coverage of the 90% predictive band. (B) Pravda network output collapses within the hour after the Vladimir outage and recovers with a partial catch-up; its Telegram input does not dip. No comparable dip follows Sasovo, where a decline started 7 h before the strike. Shading marks the most likely dip interval; vertical lines mark outage onsets (UTC).

2. Results

2.1 Infrastructure and Dependent Services

Yandex Cloud reachability fell from 23:04 UTC after the Sasovo strike (strike 22:27, full loss 00:24) and from 01:38 UTC after the Vladimir strike (strike 00:10). BGP visibility stayed intact, indicating a data-plane loss. Hosting, access and platform controls (Selectel, Timeweb, Beget, VK, Rostelecom, MTS, MegaFon, Beeline and Yandex Cloud Kazakhstan) show no

matching steps. Russian Wikipedia user traffic fell −7% in the 24 h after Vladimir, consistent with disruption of Yandex Search and apps, and complaint alerts for Yandex Pay, Go and KinoPoisk surged from 00:47 UTC.

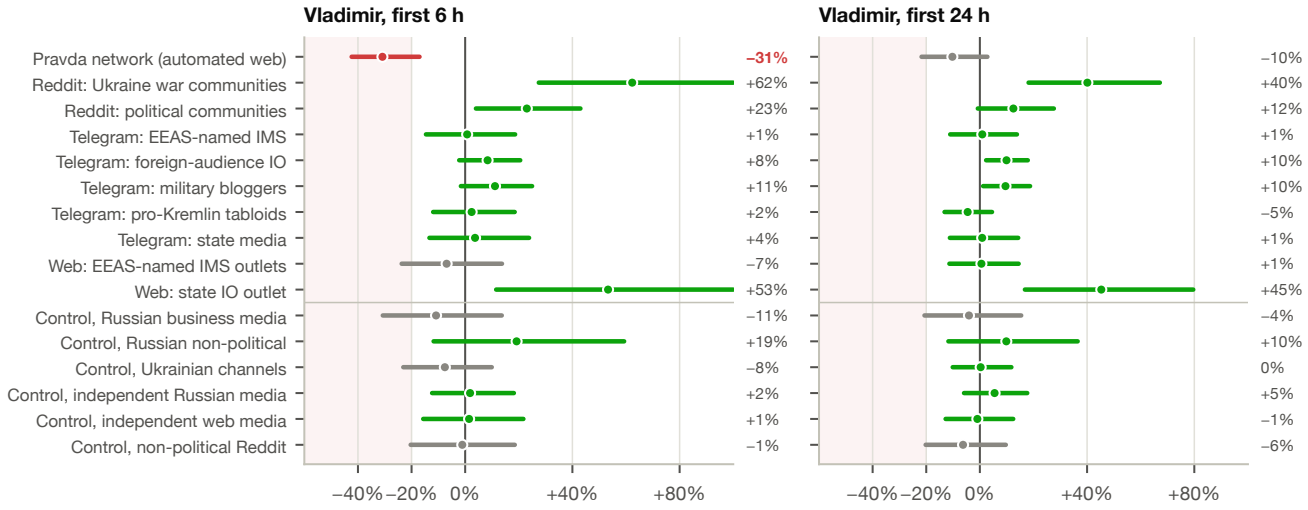
2.2 Where an Effect on Information Operations Is and Is Not Seen

- **Pravda network.** The only credible and time-locked drop (Vladimir, first 6 h: −31%, P(drop > 10%) = 99%). The English, German and French editions dip 22 min after onset.
- *Telegram.* State media, military bloggers, tabloids and foreign-audience channels (including InfoDefense, Strategic Culture, Sputnik Africa, Rybar and Slavyangrad) show no credible drop. Non-war posts of state (−26%) and tabloid channels (−19%) fell while their war posts rose (+17% and +17%); this is topic substitution toward strike news, not lost capacity.
- *EEAS-named outlets.* African Initiative and RRN websites (+1% over 24 h) and African Initiative's Telegram channels (+1%) show no credible drop and no time-locked dip.
- *Yandex 360 mail.* Outlets on Yandex mail show an extra effect of −8% (90% −17% to +2%), indistinguishable from the −7% seen in the placebo window.
- *Web and Reddit.* The RIA outlet ukraina.ru and the pro-Russian, war and political Reddit communities show no drop; war communities rose with strike news. No war-specific reduction is found on any platform.

Of 114 IO series, 58 rule out a drop larger than 20% after Vladimir, 33 are inconclusive, 19 increased and 4 show a drop that survives false-discovery control and the same-weekday check: two Pravda editions (Romanian and news-pravda.com); the non-war posts of state channels and tabloids, which is topic substitution. In the analysis of competing hypotheses, a narrow dependency of specific automated pipelines carries no weighted inconsistency, whereas a broad collapse of IO output is contradicted by every platform-level measurement.

Figure 2

Bayesian Posterior Change in Output per Platform Group After the Vladimir Strike



Note. Posterior median (value at right) and 90% credible interval, including the common news-shock variance estimated before the strikes. Red: credible drop. Green: drops larger than 20% ruled out. Grey: inconclusive. The shaded band marks drops beyond the 20% smallest effect of interest.

2.3 Infrastructure of Attributed Influence Operations

Of the 338 Storm-1516 domains listed by VIGINUM, 92 resolved and 59 answered on 13 to 14 October; the answering sites sit mainly behind Cloudflare (35) and Amazon.com (18), and most of the rest are dormant or parked, so their output cannot be measured hourly. The websites of African Initiative (afrinz.ru) and R-FBI (fondfbr.ru) are hosted by REG.RU, and those of RRN (rrn.com.tr) and the Pravda network behind Cloudflare. None of these 342 domains, and none of the 49 state and IO media domains mapped for this study, is hosted on a Yandex network or uses Yandex name servers. Seven media outlets use Yandex 360 mail (rt.com, vz.ru, readovka.news, rybar.ru, strategic-culture.su, topcor.ru, eadaily.com); their channels show no strike-specific change (Section 2.2).

3. Data Verification

Random samples of every stored source (149 values in total) were downloaded again from the original services, bypassing the cache. IODA, Wikimedia, Pravda network, Telegram, Web (WordPress API) and RIPE Stat match exactly; Reddit (Arctic Shift) matches in 83% of hours (largest difference 1, from comments deleted or added after collection). Arctic Shift aggre-

gate buckets are labelled two hours early and were corrected and checked against the raw comment stream; Reddit group totals are reported only when every member community is observed. Pravda sitemap and WordPress timestamps were checked against article publication times.

4. Limitations

- X, VK and closed bot infrastructure are not observable with open data, so small dedicated networks could go undetected. The median single-series minimum detectable drop is about 26% over 24 h, and 10 to 20% for pooled groups.
- The strikes were major news and inflated war-related activity. Theme contrasts and controls mitigate this but cannot remove it.
- The Pravda attribution rests on timing. Its sites sit behind Cloudflare, so the dependent component is not directly observable, and Sasovo, which cut reachable capacity by 34%, produced no time-locked dip.
- DNS was measured after the strikes; an outlet that moved off Yandex earlier would appear independent. Outlets blocked by the national resolver (RT, Sputnik, RIA) were mapped through public DNS but not crawled. Recovery estimates are right-censored at 13 October, 12:00 UTC.

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Data sources (graded and linked individually in the dashboard): Yandex Cloud status (status.yandex.cloud); IODA (ioda.inetintel.cc.gatech.edu); RIPE Stat (stat.ripe.net); NASA FIRMS (firms.modaps.eosdis.nasa.gov); Wikimedia pageviews (wikimedia.org/api); Arctic Shift (arctic-shift.photon-reddit.com); Telegram public previews (t.me/s); sitemaps and WordPress APIs of the outlets named in the text. Code and dashboard: github.com/stvsever/OSINT_YandexOutage.